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The rich and unyielding sultanates of Bijapur, Ahmednagar and, further south, Golconda would become, a bit like Samarqand, a holy grail and a graveyard of Mughal ambition in the subcontinent. Murad was not the last general to fail at conquering these lands; nor was he the first.

It was almost a decade since Akbar had made his first serious foray to the south. In 1586, he sent his milk brother Aziz and Shihabuddin – the man who had once been Maham Anaka's deputy – to lead a joint campaign into the Deccan. Instead, however, the two men almost went to war with each other. Aziz had managed to keep his cool in the face of Shahbaz Khan's provocations in Bengal, but Shihabuddin – Maham Anaka's trusted friend and colleague, and a possible conspirator in the murder of Aziz's father, Shamsuddin Ataka – was a different matter. For six months, writes Nizamuddin, the Mughal armies were inactive because Aziz refused to work with Shihabuddin. Finally, 'matters reached such a pitch' that Shihabuddin abandoned the mission and left for home, at which Aziz lost his previous lassitude and began to march – not to the Deccan but after his colleague. A 'dire calamity was upon the point of falling upon the royal army', writes Nizamuddin; it was narrowly averted.

Akbar and Aziz's relations had mended somewhat after Aziz helped secure Bengal, but Aziz's temper and tongue were still as sharp. Badauni tells of how, when Aziz returned from Bengal to Fatehpur in the early 1580s, Akbar's koka launched into another tirade against Akbar's policies and his new friends – including Abul Fazl and Birbar – carrying 'his speech to [such] wonderful excesses . . . that he became the common talk of high and low'. He left the court in high dudgeon 'on pretext of letting his beard grow' – shorthand, presumably, for practising his religion, not Akbar's. Eventually, Akbar wrote to him, asking, 'Is your beard not yet grown that you do not come?' Aziz sent 'a long and rude letter in reply, which made an impression on the Emperor's mind'.[69]

Akbar did not, however, arrest his friend; Aziz went and exiled himself. In 1593, seven-odd years after the debacle with Shihabuddin, Aziz 'put his children and his wives and treasures into a boat'[70] and sailed off to Mecca. From there, it seems, he wrote another letter, declaring that 'it would be only fit . . . to take this body to the Sacred dust of Mecca' in preference to